praxes; and established labor structures or hierarchies. All of these factors together flexibly constituted the architectural culture operative in a permeably delineated *locus*, which served as the principal resource for architectural patronage among elite and non-elite echelons alike.

It must be emphasized that an architectural culture at a moment in time was far from monolithic, and the concept should be capacious in its synchronous application. Here, I find Holly Edwards's[45] notion of "spectrum piety" applicable within an architectural context: the virtually infinite historical iterations of an architectural culture spanned a wide spectrum, encompassing elite patronage, which is typically thought to set far-reaching, cosmopolitan standards. But not all structures in a given time and space were commissioned by elites or built by the same artisans. Since non-elite patronage also manifested the architectural culture in question, all its iterations should be viewed with parity, as points on the spectrum spanning elite or royal, cosmopolitan patronage, through non-elite or vernacular commissions. Rather than one being of lesser or greater value, *all* instantiations of an identifiable architectural culture serve as valid and equally valuable historical informants.

As such, an architectural culture would rarely evince drastic and sudden changes with shifts in political régimes, for example, or even the introduction of new religious practices.[46] Really, new architectural cultures took root within a region only with the influx of skilled laborers *and* the availability of the required building materials, both in terms of natural resources (e.g., stone deposits, earth usable for bricks) and "industrial" infrastructure (quarries, kilns, and fuel, etc.). In fact, multiple architectural cultures could co-exist within a region,[47] as the mobility of skilled laborers is a known phenomenon,[48] with the demands for their skills depending on the vagaries of their patrons' preferences. But while a regional, politico-economic elite by definition commandeered material resources and labor toward their own requirements, political shifts did not abruptly or even necessarily interrupt the inertia of a region's architectural culture(s), or the ways in which buildings were constructed or decorated. At the same time, it is also true that all *un*mechanized human practices change, more or less perceptibly, over time. The relationship between architectural patronage and the built form, then, cannot always be characterized in general terms, but largely on an individual and ad hoc basis.

The tomb of Salar Khalil (also known as the *ziyarat* of Baba Khatim) (Figures I.16 and I.17) in Afghanistan's Juzjan Province, about 40 km west of Balkh, and the tomb locally attributed to Shahzada Shaikh Husain near Bust (Figures I.18 and I.19) both serve as discrete and informative exemplars of an architectural culture in general, and in particular as manifestations of greater Khurasan's architectural culture, which occupies the majority of this Volume.[49] Along with *minar*s, and mosque and *madrasa* complexes, the "domed cube" configuration of these tombs was